

THE “OLD RELIGION”

Stregheria

The Italian-American witchcraft movement, Stregheria, claims to hark back to an imagined Italian folk tradition with roots in the pre-Roman, pre-Christian Etruscan people of central Italy in the first millennium BCE. According to Stregheria, the Etruscans’ belief system survived Roman repression and assimilation as a deeply rooted peasant tradition brought to light only at the end of the 19th century. It is as a result of these purported ancient roots that Stregheria is also known as *La Vecchia Religione*, the Old Religion.

The spiritual inheritance

Stregheria is based on the 1899 publication *Aradia or the Gospel of the Witches* (see below), which allegedly contains the sacred text of a pagan Italian witch cult. The forms of worship it describes—veneration of male and female deities and the natural world and its seasons, and celebration of equinoxes and solstices—resemble those of Wicca (see pp.264–267).

► Etruscan Diana

Diana, the divine huntress and goddess of the moon, is one of the ancient deities worshipped in Stregheria. Here, she is depicted in a 4th-century BCE bronze figure discovered at Nemi, the sanctuary dedicated to her in central Italy.

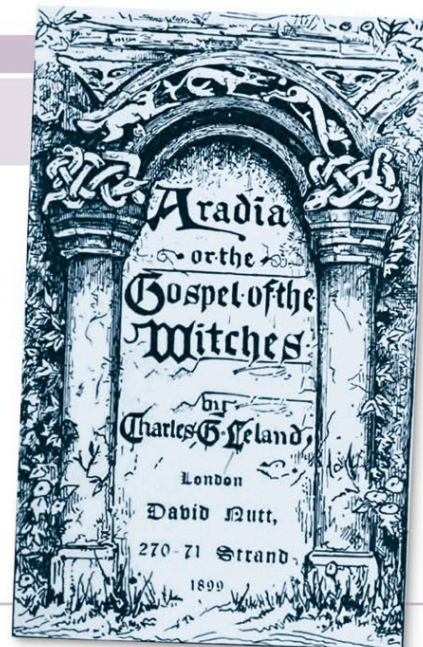
The modern movement of Stregheria began in the 1970s with the writings of Italian-American Leo Louis Martello. He described his initiation by relatives into beliefs similar to those in the story of Aradia, but the Sicilian cult of Demeter, goddess of harvest, and her daughter Persephone also influenced his family’s witchcraft, and they saw the Virgin Mary as a variant of Demeter. In 1995, American author Raven Grimassi, drawing on Wiccan practices and also claiming initiation into a secret tradition of Italian magic, published *Ways of the Strega*. Both authors helped strengthen and spread Stregheria, especially in Australia, with its substantial Italian-Australian population.

IN CONTEXT

The bearer of light

US folklorist Charles Leland wrote *Aradia or the Gospel of the Witches*, the book that sparked the Stregheria movement. It was based on Leland’s exchange with a Florentine fortune-teller called Maddalena, who told him of an ancient Italian witchcraft tradition. Still in existence, its witches worshipped the goddess Diana, her brother (and lover) Lucifer—the “bearer of light”—and their daughter, Aradia, who came to earth to teach magic. The book describes the tradition’s rituals, spells, and beliefs, and became popular in the 1960s, although its authenticity is subject to debate.

According to the author of *Aradia*, the book is a sacred text of Stregheria.



“This Stregheria, or old religion, is something more than a sorcery, and something less than a faith.”

CHARLES LELAND, *ARADIA OR THE GOSPEL OF THE WITCHES*, 1899

